

FUTURE SKILLS SERIES

AI Literacy • Lesson 3 of 6

THE FACT DESK LESSON

Hallucination Hunters

Smooth is not the same as **true**.

Grades 6–8

45-min lesson

No prep • No devices needed



THE COMET • FACT DESK SHIFT

The Fact Desk



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

A note from Deja, the editor of The Comet, the school paper: "You're on the fact desk. Three writers used an AI helper. AI predicts likely words, and it doesn't always check them. So it can be totally wrong and still sound sure. No story gets printed until you check it."

Desk words: **run:** it gets printed **log:** write it down
column: one writer's regular story **stamp:** your verdict box. Pick one.
second source: a place to check that is NOT where you first saw the claim
the ending still stands: it's still true once the facts are fixed

Your method, every draft: Stuck? The Desk Helpers are on p.2.

- **1. UNDERLINE** every checkable claim (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes).
- **2. RANK** — write **C** above claims to CHECK, **S** above SAFE ones.
- **3. LATERAL-READ** — leave the draft. Log a second source that could confirm each claim.
- **4. VERDICT** — pick one stamp, give your evidence, and say if the writer's ending still stands.

Typeable PDF? You can't underline, so type your C claims into the table. Skip the S ones.

🔍 DRAFT #1 — PRIYA'S SCIENCE COLUMN "MOON FACTS"

The Moon is Earth's only natural satellite. Astronauts first landed on the Moon in 1959, and Neil Armstrong was the first person to walk on its surface. By 1972, 12 people had walked on the Moon. On a clear night the Moon seems to shine because it produces its own light — which is why it's the brightest thing in the night sky.

Log your two riskiest claims — the two that would hurt The Comet most if they're wrong.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	
☐ RUN — clean, print it	☐ FIX — correct it, then print	☐ KILL — cut the story	

Note to Priya — what's wrong, your second source, and does her ending still stand?

Need a start? What's wrong: _____. I would check _____. The ending still stands / falls because _____.

THE FACT DESK LESSON • LESSON 3 OF 6

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A 45-minute AI fact-checking lesson. Students run the fact desk at the school paper, and nothing gets printed until they clear it. They learn why AI can sound sure and still be wrong, plus a four-step method for catching it. Stands alone.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	The Fact Desk worksheet (3 pages, 1 per student) • Slides (optional) • the board, for the RUN / FIX / KILL tally • pencils	None. With devices, desks open the source they named and check their C claims.	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN...

- Explain why AI "hallucinates": it predicts likely words, so it can be confidently wrong. (*Exit #1*)
- Identify the checkable claims in a text (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes) and rank them by risk. (*draft #1*)
- Lateral-read a claim (name a second, independent source that could confirm it) and give an evidence-based verdict: RUN, FIX, or KILL. (*second-source column + stamp*)

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

CCSS ELA RI.6.8

ISTE 1.3.b

ISTE 1.3.d

Full text + taught/assessed map for each code in the Teacher's Guide.

DIFFERENTIATION

- Support:** Drafts #1–2 only. In Round 2, *both partners* take Draft #2 and swap as normal. Hint: "Each draft hides two false facts, plus a shaky ending."
- Extension:** Write a smooth four-sentence passage with ONE planted error, or none at all. Trade. Your partner has to decide: RUN, FIX, or KILL.
- ELL:** Label the claim TYPE (name, date, number, place, quote) above each underline; partners read aloud; desk words glossed on p.1.
- 2-device classrooms:** built in. Students name the source they would check. **With devices**, they open it.

WARM-UP — THE STORY THAT ALMOST RAN (6 MIN)

Read this aloud, smooth and confident, like a news anchor. Then call the vote: "This is going in tomorrow's paper. Print it?"

"Our solar system has eight planets orbiting one star, the Sun. The closest planet to the Sun is Venus, which is also the hottest. Mars is called the Red Planet because rusty iron dust covers its surface. Saturn is famous for its rings — it is the only planet in our solar system that has them. Sunlight takes about eight minutes to reach Earth."

Expect most of the room to vote print. Reveal: **two sentences are false**. Mercury is closest to the Sun (Venus really is the hottest — the half-truth is what makes it slippery), and Saturn isn't alone: Jupiter, Uranus, and Neptune have faint rings too.

If the room votes HOLD: ask which sentence they doubt — most name Saturn and miss Venus. "One doubt is a start. The desk finds BOTH." If a kid names Venus instantly: "Write it down. We vote first, then we check." The second error usually slips past anyway.

Bridge (say it): "That sounded right because it was SMOOTH, not because it was TRUE. AI predicts likely words, and it doesn't always check them. So it can sound exactly like that. Today you're the fact desk: nothing gets printed until you clear it."

KEY — "SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT" COLUMN

The ISTE 1.3.b item. Full credit: a specific KIND of source, independent of the draft and of the AI. Partial: "look it up online" or "Google it" with no site named. No credit: asked the AI again; the draft itself.

DRAFT	ACCEPTABLE SECOND SOURCES	WHAT FAILS
#1 Moon	A space-agency page (NASA) on Apollo 11 or the Moon; an encyclopedia entry "Moon"; a science textbook's astronomy chapter.	"Ask the AI if it's sure"; a video that repeats the claim; a quiz site that copied the claim.
#2 Records	An atlas or globe; an encyclopedia entry on Everest or Australia; a geography textbook; the Australian government's own site.	A quiz site that copied the claim; a friend who "knows"; the draft itself.
#3 Inventions	An encyclopedia entry on Bell, Edison, or the telephone; a museum site (Smithsonian); a history textbook. For the quote: a quotation reference or a collection of Edison's writings. Nothing turns up, so it has no source.	"It's in quotation marks, so it's real"; asking the AI "did Edison say this?"

EXIT TICKET KEY

#1 — How can AI sound 100% sure and still be wrong? Full credit names the mechanism of a predicts likely words, and it doesn't always check them. Confidence is a writing style, not evidence. Accept "it guesses what sounds right" or "it's a smooth talker, not a fact-checker." Partial credit: "it makes mistakes" with no why.

#2 — A real checkable claim + a second source that is NOT where they first saw or heard it. Full credit names a claim with a name, date, number, place, or quote in it AND a specific second source ("the NASA site, not the video that made the claim"; "a news site that didn't copy the first one"). Model: "A video said goldfish only remember things for three seconds. I'd check an encyclopedia entry on goldfish, not the video." Partial: "look it up online" or "Google it" with no site named. Push back: "Google shows you ten sources. Which one, and why that one?" No credit: "ask the AI again."

FULL STANDARDS TEXT

- **CCSS ELA R.1.2** — Trace and evaluate the argument and specific claims in a text, distinguishing claims that are supported by reasons and evidence from claims that are not. Taught: Fact-desk method steps 1 and 4 (underline claims; test the ending). Assessed: the RUN/FIX/KILL stamp + note on each draft ("does the ending still stand?").
- **ISTE 1.3.b** — Students evaluate the accuracy, perspective, credibility and relevance of information, media, data or other resources. Taught: lateral reading, step 3. Assessed: the "Second source" column on each draft (key above) + Exit Ticket #2.
- **ISTE 1.3.d** — Students build knowledge by actively exploring real-world issues and problems, developing ideas and theories and pursuing answers and solutions. Taught: The Fact Desk activity — desks pursue verification and defend verdicts in "Verdicts out loud." Assessed: Exit Ticket #2 (a real claim from their own week, and where they would check it).

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